

The Great Basin Desert

North America's largest desert, where moisture arrives as snow—if it arrives at all



With an area of about 200,000 square miles (518,000 square km), the Great Basin is the largest desert in North America. It lies mainly in Nevada and western Utah, but stretches into California and Idaho.

Classified as a cold desert, the Great Basin's elevations range from 3,900 to 9,800 ft (1,200 to 3,000 m). The Sierra Nevada and the Rocky Mountain ranges block most moisture from the Pacific Ocean and Gulf of Mexico, forming a rain-shadow area. So the average annual precipitation is only 12 in (30 cm), and usually arrives as snow. A single "wet year" can often be followed by many years of drought.

Habitats here vary greatly, with mountaintop "islands" of bristlecone or pinyon and juniper forests separated by sagebrush-filled valleys or arid salt lakes—in some places, the soil is so salty that no plants can survive.

Bristlecones can live for more than 5,000 years

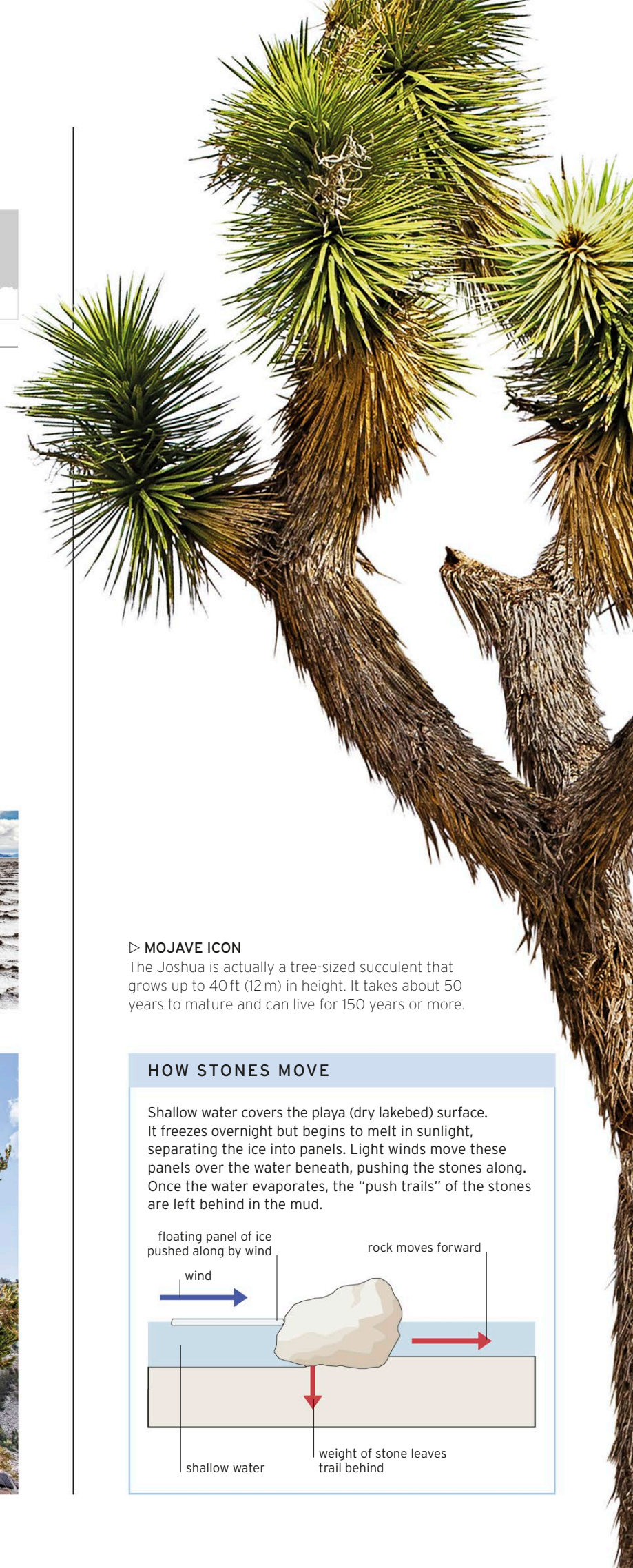
▷ BONNEVILLE SALT FLATS

The flats are covered with water in winter, which evaporates in summer, leaving behind crystallized salt.



▽ BRISTLECONE LANDSCAPE

Bristlecones are found at high altitudes and in harsh conditions. They are more disease-resistant and at lesser risk of wildfires than many other desert plants.



▷ MOJAVE ICON

The Joshua is actually a tree-sized succulent that grows up to 40 ft (12 m) in height. It takes about 50 years to mature and can live for 150 years or more.

HOW STONES MOVE

Shallow water covers the playa (dry lakebed) surface. It freezes overnight but begins to melt in sunlight, separating the ice into panels. Light winds move these panels over the water beneath, pushing the stones along. Once the water evaporates, the "push trails" of the stones are left behind in the mud.

